Same Message, Different Reading? Testing Whether LLM-Labelled Political Opinion Travels Across Scripts and Platforms in Pakistan and India

Research proposal, PhD in Communications and New Media, National University of Singapore (August 2027 intake) · Asad Ikram · asad.ikram53@gmail.com
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1. Problem

Large language models are becoming the default instrument for reading political opinion from social media (Gilardi, Alizadeh and Kubli, 2023). The instrument is sensitive: labels change with the model and prompt, often enough to reverse conclusions (Baumann et al., 2025; Messing, 2026); multilingual analysis must show equivalence across languages (Lind et al., 2025); and the platform is a named source of error in digital trace data (Sen et al., 2021). Evidence is missing where these problems meet. In Pakistan and India the same political talk appears in Urdu script, Roman Urdu, English and Hinglish, and different audiences comment under the same news story on YouTube and Facebook. If an LLM reads these versions differently, comparisons may reflect the instrument rather than the public.

2. Prior work

Platform differences can be real: commenters self-select, and more uncivil users comment more (Kim, Guess, Nyhan and Reifler, 2021), and work at CNM shows that the link between engagement metrics and news production differs by platform (Mukerjee, Yang and Peng, 2023; Ouyang, Mukerjee and Yang, 2026). Labels can also shift by language on identical content, which only designs that hold content fixed can reveal (Nogara et al., 2025), and romanised Indian-language text can be handled worse than native script (Khullar et al., 2025), although LLM political labels are sometimes similar across languages (Hartman and Törnberg, 2026). The core problem is identification: a gap between platforms or scripts may be a real difference in what people say or an error in how the model reads them. Corrections with a human sample (Egami et al., 2023) help only if the human reference is valid for each group. With Dr Ella Haig I released a protocol for testing whether the platform acts as a source of measurement error, by analogy to survey modes (Ikram and Haig, 2026, preprint); its simulation shows how pooling misleads when the platform mix shifts, but it has not been applied to real data.

3. Why I am asking this question

For nearly eight years I have turned social media into numbers that others act on. At Dubizzle Labs in Lahore I built the first web-data system for six products across nine Middle Eastern countries and saw that Arabic, Urdu and Hindi text does not behave like English. My Chevening proposal grew from Pakistan's protests over electricity bills in 2023: I wanted public bodies to read public reaction before such decisions, not after. My MSc dissertation (255,446 comments on UK economic policy across four platforms) was a first attempt, and it taught me the lesson behind this proposal: my classifier's 88 per cent "accuracy" was agreement with the lexicon labels it was trained on, and my English-only pipeline had silently dropped every Urdu and Hindi post. I met the same problem again at M+C Saatchi Fluency, building LLM tagging for global brands, and as co-founder and CTO of Artemis AI, where our evaluation showed that agreement between models is not accuracy (Kim et al., 2025). Industry gives me the questions, but not the time, ground truth or peer review to answer them.

4. Research questions

1. **Scripts.** When the same political message is written in Urdu script, Roman Urdu, English and Hinglish, do LLMs assign the same stance and sentiment as Pakistani and Indian coders, and does this depend on the model?
2. **Platforms.** When the same outlet posts the same story on YouTube and Facebook, how much of the gap in comment stance is LLM error that differs by platform, and how much is a difference in what audiences express?
3. **Consequences.** Does correcting for this non-equivalence change a substantive Pakistan-India comparison around fixed events, and at what sample sizes?

5. Data and methods

Study 1 (year 1). With native speakers, build about 300 political messages in four parallel versions, plus real bilingual pairs where politicians post the same message in two languages. Pakistani coders label Urdu and Roman Urdu, Indian coders Hinglish, both English; three or four frozen open-weight LLMs and a fine-tuned code-mixed model label the same items. A rater model (Dawid and Skene, 1979) tests whether model-human disagreement differs by script, and a design study sizes the later studies. This yields a Roman Urdu and Urdu political-stance gold set, extending Hinglish resources (Swami et al., 2018; Patwa et al., 2020).

Study 2 (years 2 to 3). Collect comments under the same stories from 10 to 20 matched outlets and party accounts per country on YouTube (Researcher Program) and Facebook Pages (Meta Content Library, with the same open-weight models inside Meta's secure environment), around events fixed in advance such as each country's budget. A small Singapore arm (English and Singlish comments under Singapore outlets' stories) gives a platform contrast with no change of script. A stratified sample is double-coded, so platform-specific LLM error can be separated from audience differences.

Study 3 (years 3 to 4). Re-run a Pakistan-India comparison with uncorrected and corrected labels and report when the conclusion changes and when it does not; a null result supports comparisons the field already makes. NUS ethics review; public pages only; no user identities.

6. Why NUS CNM, and feasibility

The project sits in computational and political communication, across CNM's Politics, Participation and Governance and Technology, Design and Social Futures clusters. Dr Subhayan Mukerjee's work on news, audiences and platforms, and on India, makes him the natural primary supervisor; RQ2 takes his platform-dependent findings from news production to the measurement of audience reaction. Dr Zening Duan's work on operationalising measures (Duan et al., 2025) and on comparison across platforms (Chen, Duan and Kim, 2024) connects to RQ1, and work by Associate Professors Taberez Neyazi and Kokil Jaidka on South Asian political communication (Jaidka et al., 2019) and Assistant Professor Ozan Kuru on public opinion would inform RQ3. Study 1 needs no platform access; I speak Urdu and Hindi, which helps with codebook design, while trained native coders do the coding.

7. Expected contribution

An applied rather than methodological contribution: a test of whether LLM opinion labels mean the same across South Asian scripts and platforms, using designs that hold the message fixed; a Roman Urdu and Urdu political-stance gold set; and evidence on whether these differences change conclusions, including where they do not. A first paper is planned for *Computational Communication Research*.

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